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"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, sunny to partly cloudy, warm, light winds, high 71. **Tonight,** clear to partly cloudy, light winds, low 51. **Tomorrow,** sunny and cooler, high 71. Weather map appears on Page D8.

VOL. CLXXVI .... No. 61,049 © 2026 The New York Times Company MONDAY, OCTOBER 26, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $4.00



REUTERS

Smoke billowed last month from Mansouri in southern Lebanon, one of dozens of villages to have been targeted by the Israeli military.

Rising Fears and Threats Risk a Wider War in Iran

Both Sides Said to Plot Strikes, as Elections in U.S. and Israel Add to the Danger

This article is by ***David E. Sanger****,* ***Julian E. Barnes****,* ***Jonathan Swan****,* ***Maggie Haberman****,* ***Farnaz Fassihi*** *and* ***Eric Schmitt****.*

WASHINGTON — Inside the Trump administration, officials are expressing fears that Iran is in the "advanced stages" of planning attacks against U.S. officials.

More than 6,000 miles away, the Iranians appear convinced that Israel and the United States are preparing to unleash their third major attack in 16 months, a final push to force Iran to surrender to U.S. demands.

The conflict in the Middle East has entered a new phase in which a maelstrom of factors, from the political calendars in the United States and Israel to the potential for all sides to be seeking pretexts for action, is creating heightened levels of tension and risk.

This is how countries can escalate into full-scale war, several diplomats and outside experts noted. If the U.S. intelligence disclosed last week is right that Iran has credible plans to attack Americans at home and abroad, one senior European official said — "and it probably is," the official added — one gunshot that appears aimed at a U.S. official could touch off a conflagration. So could a stray explosion near a bunker sheltering Iranian leaders, who already survived their predecessors' deaths in a decapitation strike in the opening hours of the war on Feb. 28.

The fact that Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel and President Trump are facing critical elections that could drastically affect the balance of power in their countries feeds into the complex set of calculations that all sides are making. Even if he is defeated on Tuesday, Mr. Netanyahu could decide to launch one last strike that he may believe his successor would hesitate to execute. Similarly, Mr. Trump, who knows how unpopular the war is even among his strongest supporters, may want to show that at least when it comes to his powers as commander in chief, his authority is undiminished.

And, as in other moments of global peril — the Cuban Missile Crisis and the decision to invade in Iraq, as examples — partial or faulty intelligence, or just a failure to understand the adversary's true motives, can carry deadly consequences. Iraq poses another cautionary tale, when selective intelligence can be used as an actual pretext for military action.

U.S. officials say they are focused on elements of the most recent intelligence suggesting that the Iranians may seek to kill U.S. ambassadors in the Middle East and American officials on U.S. soil — a longtime ambition of Iran's elite Unit 840, which has carried out kidnappings and assassinations around the globe. But history suggests Iran's desires often outstrip its capabilities. It has at times hired hapless hit men who have been arrested before they could do harm.

Continued on Page A6

D.O.J. ESCALATING ELECTION TACTICS

Taking Up a President's Demands This Term

This article is by ***Glenn Thrush****,* ***Katie Rogers*** *and* ***Zolan Kanno-Youngs****.*

WASHINGTON — The Justice Department is sharply intensifying efforts to intervene in the midterm elections, goaded by a president unfettered by even the limited restraints of his first term.

The next several weeks represent a critical moment for federal law enforcement, a test of whether a department repurposed by President Trump as an instrument of unmediated executive power will be effectively mobilized as a guarantor of his political power.

In recent weeks, the department has taken several new steps, including an extraordinary effort to invalidate any potential Democratic victory in the Alaska Senate race, that reflect Mr. Trump's growing agitation as his party faces the possibility of losing control of Congress precipitated by his sagging popularity.

On Thursday, the department asked a federal court to block certification of the election if the incumbent, Senator Dan S. Sullivan, were to lose narrowly, claiming that the presence of another candidate with a nearly identical full name tainted the election. The move, the first of its kind in generations, came in response to the president's rants about the issue, officials said.

Hours after the papers were filed, Mr. Trump abandoned any pretext that department officials had acted without his say-so, telling reporters, "I'm the one that said do it."

Mr. Trump has grown agitated about the dueling Sullivans, among other election-related grievances. He has demanded the department take legal action, even as some department officials raised concerns about the merits and constitutionality of the case, according to two people with knowledge of the situation, speaking on the condition of anonymity to avoid retribution.

The episode comes amid the department's widening push to exclude large batches of mail-in votes on suspicion that some had been cast by noncitizens, despite evidence that such voting is exceedingly rare. At the same time,

Continued on Page A15

After Lebanon Cease-Fire, Israel Razed Villages

Worries Rise That Aim Is to Empty Territory Permanently

This article is by ***Christina Goldbaum****,* ***Samuel Granados*** *and* ***Adina Renner****.*

Much of a stretch of Israeli-occupied Lebanon is now a wasteland, a vast expanse of mostly destroyed villages.

A New York Times analysis of satellite imagery found that most of the villages were flattened by Israel after an April cease-fire. Israel said it wanted to remove the threats posed by Hezbollah.

Israeli forces deliberately demolished homes, schools, mosques and roads, predominantly in Shiite Muslim villages.

The cease-fire ended the worst of the fighting between Hezbollah and Israel. But it did not end Israel's remaking of southern Lebanon. Today, 48 of the roughly 60 villages and towns in Israeli-occupied southern Lebanon are mostly leveled, the Times analysis shows.

The scale of Israel's systematic demolition has fueled fears among many Lebanese that Israel is seeking to permanently empty the territory of its population.

Israeli officials say they have razed villages both to eliminate Hezbollah military facilities, like tunnels and weapons depots, and to prevent Hezbollah from returning to the border area. The Lebanese territory that the Israeli military has seized and occupied since fighting resumed in March extends as far as eight miles north of the Israeli border.

In dozens of villages, fighting between Israeli forces and Hezbollah militants during the six weeks of all-out war damaged roads and buildings.

But after the cease-fire was declared and Israel entrenched its occupation in the south, Israeli forces flattened the villages. Much of the surrounding area is now uninhabitable.

At the same time, Israeli forces built new infrastructure, suggesting plans for a prolonged military presence.

Since the April cease-fire, about 16,500 acres across this swath of

Continued on Page A8

Even If Oil Prices Come Down, Expect Airfares to Stay Costly

By NIRAJ CHOKSHI

Airfares soared because of the war with Iran. It's looking increasingly likely that prices won't come down anytime soon.

Tensions in the Middle East have risen in recent days, pushing up oil prices. But even if the war ended and fuel costs fell, ticket prices could remain stubbornly high.

Travelers, particularly affluent ones who buy high-end seats, have been undeterred so far by the higher prices. Other costs for the airlines are up. And they are facing less competition. Spirit Airlines, which once offered tickets for less than $100, shut down this spring, and other low-cost carriers are struggling.

"It's expensive to fly airplanes," Scott Kirby, the chief executive of United Airlines, told Wall Street analysts in a conference call on Wednesday. Most companies in his industry will lose money this year, so fares will have to remain high, he said. "I think the tide has to rise for everyone or those airlines simply won't exist."

In September, airfares were 22 percent more expensive than a year earlier, according to federal data. The average cost of a round-trip Thanksgiving flight within

Continued on Page A17



DAVID ZALUBOWSKI/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Airlines are prioritizing higher-value fliers over affordability.

Flipping Senate Won't Be Cinch For Democrats

By LISA LERER

Democrats have a hefty advantage in national polls. President Trump is playing defense, campaigning through deep-red corners of the country that he won by overwhelming margins just two years ago. And assumptions that Democrats will win control of Congress have become conventional wisdom in many quarters, from longtime political observers to social media to the oddsmakers in prediction markets.

But as Democratic dreams of midterm victories grow bigger, some strategists quietly worry that expanding expectations are crowding out signs of a more challenging political reality.

Control of the Senate hinges on victories in red states that favored Mr. Trump by significant margins in 2024, including some that Democrats have not won in decades. Republicans are outspending them by eye-popping amounts in key races. And after its performance in 2024, the Democratic Party as a brand still remains unpopular among voters.

All of that has left some in both parties wondering: Could the much-discussed blue wave end up looking more like a splash?

"The election can be summed up in the following sentence: Can huge amounts of Republican money defeat huge Democratic advantages in issues, candidates

Continued on Page A12



DANIELE VOLPE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Questions Linger, as Does an ICE Bullet

A year after he was pulled over by a swarm of agents and shot on his way to work, José García-Sorto is still asking why. Page A14.

A.I. School Sped Up Teaching, But Many Students Fell Behind

By DANA GOLDSTEIN

Alpha School, a fast-growing network of expensive private schools, promises to use A.I. to teach kids twice as much as they would learn in a traditional classroom in half the time. Academics take just two to three morning hours on a computer, freeing up the afternoons for workshops on vibe-coding, public speaking and sports.

The Trump administration has promoted Alpha as a model for "harnessing A.I." to prepare tomorrow's work force. Business leaders are talking it up on social media and podcasts, and some have signed up their own children.

For now, Alpha is a small, for-profit network, with lots of buzz and powerful backers, including the software billionaire Joe Liemandt. Its private schools serve about 1,500 students across 50 campuses.

But Alpha has huge ambitions to reach one billion students worldwide through its proprietary "A.I. tutor."

The plan depends partly on extending its reach into public schools. Already, the Alpha software platform has been quietly

Continued on Page A16

SPORTS D1-8

The Team-Saving Renegades
This year's Rays squad owes a debt to the 2008 version, which also made the Series and set a standard. PAGE D1

Seeking Warrior Spirit of Old
Horseback archery is making a comeback at a time when modern warfare has become impersonal. PAGE D4

INTERNATIONAL A4-10

Machado Returns to Venezuela
María Corina Machado, the Nobel laureate and opposition figure, will challenge leaders who have sidelined her and press for new elections. PAGE A5

Scrutiny for Anti-Gang Force
A U.N.-backed operation aimed at restoring order in Haiti recently had four of its soldiers taken, angering El Salvador's leader. PAGE A4

Alaska Gas Tied to Kremlin
Interviews and documents show a Russian energy giant secretly funded a U.S. firm. The deal was cited in talks to end the war in Ukraine. PAGE A10

NATIONAL 11-17, 20

An Uptick in Early Voting
In New York State, nearly twice as many voters cast their ballots on the first day of early voting compared with four years ago. PAGE A17

A Complex Bid for Release
Marci Webber was institutionalized after being convicted by reason of insanity for killing her child. PAGE A20

OBITUARIES B6

Chronicler of a Rough Life
Jim Knipfel, known for his Slackjaw column, frankly told of going blind and being in a psychiatric ward. He was 61.

ARTS C1-8

Tuning Into Christmas Early
It's not even Halloween yet, but for some Hallmark Channel fans, the time for yuletide movies is now. PAGE C1

Still Playing the Part So Well
Years after starring in "Save the Last Dance," Julia Stiles is a fan favorite on "Dancing With the Stars." PAGE C1

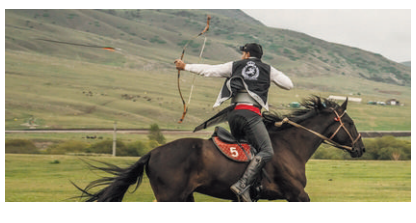
BUSINESS B1-5

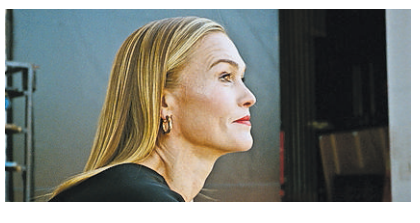
How Taiwan Elevates Women
The island has quotas for women running for public office, but now, few of them need quotas to be elected. PAGE B1

Restoring Indie TV's Glory
A new group is pushing streaming and entertainment giants to support America's independent producers. PAGE B1

OPINION A18-19

Natasha Sarin PAGE A18





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